Khrushchev was fully on board. He wanted the Cubans to withdraw their instructions. “It could seriously complicate matters if the Americans obtained information that does not correspond to reality,” read his letter to Mikoyan. Khrushchev was facing another not just embarrassing but extremely dangerous moment of being caught lying to the US president. The whole deal with Kennedy depended on mutual trust, and could collapse if that trust was broken. The information about the tactical nukes still on Cuban soil could topple the deal and launch the word into a new, even deeper crisis.[7]

On the same day, Mikoyan met with Castro to discuss further action in light of Kennedy’s statement. Castro was unhappy, and once again he did not hide his feelings from the senior Soviet official. “You feel bad that the blockade was lifted?” asked Mikoyan. Castro shot back: “No, that the blockade is lifted is not bad. It was bad that we lost the IL-28 planes.” He then sought assurance that the Soviet Union had made no promises to the United States to remove its tactical nuclear weapons. Mikoyan denied any such promises, saying that the Americans did not know about the existence of such weapons on the island, or that they were under General Pliev’s command. When Castro asked about the transfer of tactical nuclear weapons to other countries, Mikoyan cited the nonexistent law prohibiting such transfers. Mikoyan then declined Castro’s proposal to leave the nuclear weapons under Soviet command, the reason being the absence of a Soviet base in Cuba—a matter symbolically important to Castro, given his efforts to eliminate the American base at Guantánamo.[8]

The discussion moved on to other subjects, with Castro remaining as unhappy as he had been at the start of the meeting. But Mikoyan managed to do what he had believed to be right from the very beginning of the crisis —keep nuclear weapons not only out of Castro’s hands but out of Cuba altogether. This time he had Khrushchev’s full backing. The Soviet leader had finally decided to put his country’s interests above those of the communist utopia of world revolution.

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